Session 44

2026-04-19

1 - Dead island

~08:00, 15 Hammer 1490 DR

1. The group has slept on a small half-dry island in the swamp beside the mound of carnomorph corpses they killed overnight. **Chikonaui** lies dead on the ground beside them, one hand loose, throat cut with his own blade; a half-formed wing sprouting from his back.
2. From the south, **several Metagorgers** push across the water toward the island. Behind them walks a figure bigger than Nuberroca — arms set the wrong way, ribs opened backwards, a tangle of bone and muscle with huge claws — a **Shambler**. The water around them seethes with smaller bulges — **Boneleechers** surfacing.
3. Nuberroca walks back to **Juancho**, his lizard mount killed the night before, and gathers a ragged bouquet from the swamp weeds. He lays the flowers across the lizard's head and tells him he was a brave mount who could carry his weight. Noticing a twitch, he presses one of Nyx's berries into Juancho's mouth; Sinsong lays both hands on the lizard and Juancho half-rises, slow but alive.
4. The party loads into the lizardfolk boats, leaving the corpses of **Nenetl** and Chikonaui on the island. Juancho is lifted onto one boat, **Atascaburras** swims alongside.
5. Sinsong moves between the boats laying a hand on each of them in turn — party and lizardfolk alike — his bald head shining bright; he tells them they can now walk over the water. The spell lasts for an hour but Sinsong keeps renewing it as they travel.
6. Half an hour out the carnomorphs reach the island but do not pursue — they stop over the corpses and start to feed. From a distance the party watches the creatures eat, grow and evolve into new shapes.
7. During the two hours' travel Nuberroca works on reducing the pain of his grave wounds, with the help of Nyx's berries he manages to dull the worst of them.

2 - The castle in view

~10:00, 15 Hammer 1490 DR

1. The castle rises from the swamp as they close — stone, large, old, its wooden roofs mostly staved in and most of the windows either broken or boarded over. A moat rings the whole site. From the west they can distinguish three groups of buildings around it: a stockaded enclosure to the south, where giant lizards are kept, two large cane pavilions belonging to the lizardfolk in the centre outside the walls, and a cluster of bullywug-infested mud-and-filth hovels to the left.
2. Closing on the landing they realise what the patrols mean: **bullywugs and lizardfolk are both working here together**. Nobody raises an alarm as the boats pull in — nobody seems surprised at them arriving at all.
3. Sinsong and Eguzkilore pull cultist robes from the pack and shrug them on.

3 - At the shore

1. Sinsong steps off the boat and walks north across the open water to explore. The bullywugs and lizardfolk in sight pay the party little mind — but the dwarf walking on water turns every head on the quay.
2. Nuberroca asks **Atzi** and **Tompu** what the mixed camp means — *"how is it that there are lizardfolk here working with the frogs?"* The two of them answer that it is just as they had already warned him: in Naerytar, lizardfolk and bullywugs coexist, and that is exactly why they wanted the bullywugs gone. Atzi and Tompu themselves will fight; the rest of the clan might not — they obey **Dralmorrer**, and above him **Rezmir**, *the dragon lady*.
3. Nuberroca presses: if the party kills the bullywugs, will Rezmir not come down on the clan? Yes — *"so we have to finish quickly and restore order before she finds out and gets angry"*. And if the party kills Rezmir instead? *"Rezmir es buena"* — the lizardfolk will not help against her. Nuberroca argues it anyway: if she is strong and the party kills her, then the party is stronger still. The lizardfolk reply that it would make them evil.
4. Nuberroca asks for three plans with a requirement: *"uno de los planes tiene que ser violento"*. Sinsong will slip in alone, Atzi and Tompu will work the lizardfolk for sympathisers. The last plan — violence — is held in reserve.

4 – Failed exploration

1. Meanwhile Sinsong, briefly stopped by the lizardfolk guards after his water-walk and watched by curious bullywugs, is let go — unable to understand him, the guards move away and go back to their huts. Then the dwarf wanders alone to the south of the castle, out of sight of the rest of the party.
2. A moment later the dwarf is spotted flying above the walls and crash landing in a patch of vegetation at the gate; two bullywugs lean out between the crenellations above and crane down to peer further out.
3. From the gatehouse a bullywug sage with a two-handed staff steps out, lays a hand on the thickest bush, and starts to chant — seconds later the branches peel open and the cleric stands suddenly in daylight with no cover left.
4. The sage barks an order and bullywug guards sweep out of the gate to form up around him. Before the rest of the party can intervene, Sinsong is taken into the castle.

5 – Updating the plan

~11:00, 15 Hammer 1490 DR

1. With Sinsong captured, the five talk through their options in the trees ringing **Castle Naerytar**. Nuberroca suggests forcing the lizardfolk to join their cause, Mialee floats trying the bullywugs instead — their chief is the one the lizardfolk want killed, so maybe the frogs are more receptive. They decide to approach the bullywugs and look for ways into the castle while Tompu and Atzi attempt to gather sympathisers.
2. Behind the plan sits the pressure: the carnomorphs they fled by boat may be pursuing them, and the next day **Snapjaw** is expected to return with reinforcements.
3. A scream cuts out of the castle — a death-shriek in a human voice.
4. Nuberroca rides Juancho up to the lizardfolk corral and dismounts to greet the keeper. A lizardfolk reaches for Juancho's reins, admiring the fine lizard, and tries to lead him off with the others.
5. Nuberroca holds the reins, pulls a cut of crocodile meat from his pack, and splits it between Juancho and the lizardfolk — "my lizard... my horse". The keeper accepts the gift and lets the lizard be. On the way back Nuberroca ties a scrap of green cloth around Juancho's neck so he can be told apart from the other mounts if the lizardfolk herd them all together.
6. Returning to the group, Nuberroca grins: *"creo que he hecho un amigo"*.

6 – The dead bullywug

1. While Nuberroca is at the corral, Nyx wades across the river to a bullywug corpse half-sunk in the shallows and crouches to read it without touching.
2. The cut is behind the neck; the body is drained but the ground around it holds no blood — the kill happened elsewhere, and the body was dragged here from the bullywug village.
3. There is a note on the chest, in bad, irregular handwriting — "don't bury me". There are smears of blood on the paper but none on the ground where the body lies.
4. Nyx reads it as a staged suicide: the cut from behind doesn't match, and someone bothered to write a note. Factional friction inside the bullywug village — perhaps even two groups turning on each other.
5. To test the read, the heroes walk across to the bullywug compound itself — but sentries at the edge cut them off: cultists aren't allowed into the village. Mialee asks about their chief; the sentry answers that **Pharblex** isn't available and that any audience with him would be held in the breeding chambers under the castle, not here.
6. Turned back, the party loops the full perimeter of the castle. The curtain wall is complete; the moat rings the whole site; the only accessible break they find is a ragged gap on the northeast section.

7 – Inside the walls

~12:00, 15 Hammer 1490 DR

1. ***[EPIC]*** Eguzkilore walks in wearing cultist robes, Mialee behind him with a cultist emblem over plain clothes, Nyx trailing with her Harpers pendant tucked out of sight. Nuberroca stays outside the walls — too big to disguise, Torm's fist still shining on the front of his breastplate. Inside, the stone floor of the hall is a half-and-half mire of mud and bullywug filth; a narrow trodden path kept clear runs from the gate to the inner passage, and the place reeks.
2. From a forge somewhere they can hear hammers. The hammers stop, and ten or fifteen seconds later a single short, agonised scream from a woman reaches them.
3. A pale bald-headed warrior with tattoos tracing his scalp comes out of the forge dragging the drained body of a woman with one hand, and a greatsword with the other, his own similar blade still at his hip. When he spots Eguzkilore in cultist colours, he throws the corpse at him.
4. Eguzkilore catches it and tries to simply move on, but a guard grabs him from behind: "haven't you been given an order? What are you doing?". Nyx steps in with hood half-up: she is a new recruit, no uniform yet, and Eguzkilore is showing her the castle. The lie holds.
5. The guard tells Eguzkilore "you know what to do with the body" — and sends them on. Eguzkilore shoulders it and walks out with the others close behind.

8 – The drained woman

1. Outside the walls they gather around the body by the river's edge. The woman's clothes are a labourer's, and her face is so dried that her age is unreadable.
2. There is a single clean puncture at the heart; the stain on her shirt around the cut is no wider than a fingertip, where it should have soaked half the fabric. Mialee reads it as the smell of dead magic — something of a necromancer. The blood went somewhere — into a vessel, into a ritual — not into the clothes.
3. Eguzkilore lights a fire with a small druidic trick and they burn the body on the river bank; Nyx says a few words over her to Yondalla. They tell any lizardfolk who ask that they are clearing carrion before the carnomorphs come for it.

9 – Lizardfolk report

~14:00, 15 Hammer 1490 DR

1. Tompu and Atzi come back around two in the afternoon. One lizardfolk in three is willing to take up arms against the bullywugs — more than they had hoped — though none of them will take up arms against the cult itself.
2. **Dralmorrer** is well-liked among the lizardfolk — he teaches them the hammer — and the *lady dragon's* authority binds the clan from above. Snapjaw's name still carries weight and will help the rally.
3. Pharblex killed **Suncaller**, the lizardfolks' strongest shaman, with his own hand. He is always flanked by an escort, and he lives in the subterranean chambers beneath the castle. The castle doors are the only way the lizardfolk know of, but bullywugs disappear into the moat and never surface, so there must be another way down through the water.

10 – Carnomorph bait

1. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca lays out a different plan: lure the carnomorphs to the castle and let them tear through the bullywug village while the party moves on Pharblex. He meets Tompu and Atzi's protests head-on — the pavilions can be rebuilt ten kilometres further north, and the day they die in their beds they will wish they had taken this chance to rise from their ashes. The rhetoric lands: both lizardfolk agree.
2. Mialee and Nyx talk him down from the plan. Before anyone bets on carnomorphs they want to see if the water route is passable at all — if Pharblex can be reached quietly, there is no need to invite devourers in. Nuberroca floats scouting for carnomorph tracks nearby, then changes his mind and comes with them to the moat in case the crocodiles need pushing back.

11 – The moat crocodiles

1. After retrieving Juancho, the group moves around to the back of the castle, on the east, where Tompu says the bullywugs enter the water. The moat here is dark with castle run-off and at least five metres deep.
2. Nyx steps in to probe for the opening. A crocodile breaks surface, locks onto her leg, and drags her under — Nuberroca charges in and hauls her out, splitting the thing with his polearm as it hits land.
3. Mialee drops a scrap of ration into the water with a conjured hand and a second, larger crocodile breaches, lunges, and knocks Nuberroca flat; its jaws close on him twice in a row, and its tail lashes, leaving him bloodied in the mud. Juancho and Atascaburras shy away from the water.
4. Eguzkilore and Nyx put arrows into it while Nuberroca gets back on his feet. Atzi steps up to defend Eguzkilore and finishes a smaller crocodile with a mace, and Nuberroca drops the big one on the next swing.
5. Nuberroca drags the carcasses onto the bank for Juancho and Atascaburras to feed on and settles in to butcher the rest for meat; Mialee's conjured-hand sweep of the water shows no further movement.

12 – A winding tunnel

~14:30, 15 Hammer 1490 DR

1. Mialee drops in and feels her way along the stone — her darkvision is good enough in the pitch-black water for this — and finds the opening: a slit narrow enough that Nuberroca would have to force it, with a thin current drawing water inward. She has a conjured hand carry one end of a fifty-foot rope across to Eguzkilore on the bank, then goes back in with Nyx behind her, both hands on the line.
2. Mialee and Nyx fill their lungs with air and dive through the opening. Eguzkilore will haul on the rope if either tugs; Nuberroca stands ready to help pull.
3. First dive, fork right then left, forty feet down the passage dead-ends in slits too narrow to squeeze through — water passes, they do not. They retrieve and surface.
4. Nuberroca lashes three ropes together — a hundred and fifty feet total. Second dive, right-right-right at the next fork, another dead end. Third dive, right-right-left, the rope runs out before the tunnel does. They turn back; they have half their breath left.
5. Mialee is at her limit. Nyx goes on alone, pulling the rope with her.

13 – Breeding chamber

1. ***[EPIC]*** Nyx takes the last of the branches — right, right, left — and keeps swimming when the rope runs out, feeling her way through a narrow squeeze that loosens as she passes it. She surfaces into a dim-lit underground lake and sees large tadpoles cutting past her in the water.
2. Only her head above the surface, she holds still — this is the breeding chamber below the castle, exactly where the lizardfolk told them Pharblex sits. She takes a breath, drops back under, and feels her way out along the rope.
3. Back at the shore she reports: the final branch opens into a lake under the castle, and the squeeze will take even Nuberroca with rope help from the others on the far side.